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ABSTRACT
The deficiency of educational resources is typically held as one of the major impediments to the educational development of Tibetans in China. Even though the Chinese state has committed to supportive policies and providing resources to the region, the academic performance of Tibetan students remains low. The current study examines how students' family life affects their academic performance in schools. Based on the fieldwork in two Tibetan-serving boarding schools in Northwest China, we found that family absence and family education have a profound impact on Tibetan children's academic learning. Drawing on the sociology of education literature, we analyzed the tri-factors of family socioeconomic status (SES), family structure, and values. Our analysis revealed that even with an increased level of resource input, family factors contributed to Tibetan students' disappointing academic achievement. Our analysis suggested that well-intended educational policies cannot entirely substitute for the disadvantages caused by an absent family.

KEYWORDS
Family absence; Tibetan family education; Tibetan family structure; Tibetan household SES; Tibetan parents; Tibetan students

Introduction

Education in China's Tibetan regions is typically framed as an "access" or "resource deficit" issue, and much of the past research has focused on school attendance (Li et al. 2017), educational resources (Postiglione 2008, 2009), and the state's policies toward Tibetans (Yang 2019). Problems such as low household socioeconomic status (SES) (Postiglione 2013), lack of educational infrastructure (Wang and Zhou 2003), poor teaching quality (Postiglione 2008), residential disadvantages (Hannum 2002), language barriers (Beckett and Postiglione 2012), culturally irrelevant curriculum (Postiglione and Jiao 2009), dim job prospects (Bangsbo 2008), and disillusioned ethnic belonging (Yang 2017) have been regarded as common obstacles to Tibetan students' academic learning and the development of education in Tibetan regions.

Under such frames, various measures have been implemented by the state as well as local governments to ensure a consistent enrollment rate and positive educational outcomes in rural and ethnic areas. Programs such as "Education Consolidation Policy" (ECP), "Two Basics Project" (TBP), "Prevent Dropout and Ensure Compulsory Education" (PDECE), and "Two Exemptions and One Subsidy" (TEOS) have been implemented since 2001.[1] These programs are designed to guarantee access, stabilize

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and optimize resources allocation, and eventually improve education quality. In Qinghai province, where we conducted this research, the local government has implemented various educational policies in recent decades to ensure the quality of education for ethnic minority students. For example, the "Educational Relocation" policy was issued in parallel with the aforementioned national-level provisions. The policy aims to place ethnic minority children from poor households in centralized facilities with good educational resources (Tong and Zhou 2023). Moreover, local policies—such as abolishing the tuition fees of ethnic/rural schools, increasing the access of ethnic minority students to schools, providing bilingual education in public ethnic schools, lowering admission scores for ethnic students, recruiting more bilingual and well-educated teachers, and strengthening bilingual teacher training—have also been implemented in Qinghai (Tong and Zhou 2023; Wang 2007; Zhang and Tsung 2019). These programs seem to be working: as of October 2010, the middle school enrollment rate of Tibetan regions in Qinghai was up to 81.8% due to the implementation of the aforementioned policies (Padma-Lhundrup 2012).

But even with broadened access, in Qinghai, the Tibetan children's poor academic achievement constantly makes schooling a daunting challenge. The data from this study are collected mainly in two relocated Tibetan-serving schools in Qinghai, the TsuGur school and the Raja school (see details below). Both schools are supported by the "Educational Relocation" policy. Both schools are free of charge but require the students to board at the school, a significant distance from their homes. The assumption was that Tibetan children from poor pastoral regions could get high-quality educational resources and achieve a bright future when living and learning in such advanced settings.

Despite the students enjoying state-of-the-art facilities, many Tibetan students we observed and interviewed admitted that they still struggled with learning. School administrators also told us that students did very poorly on standardized tests. In the TsuGur school, around 80% of the junior students scored between 100-400 points on an 850-point test. Senior students did not show much improvement either, with an average score of around 300 points on a 750-point test. Despite Tibetan students being administered a much simpler college matriculation exam (i.e., *minkaomin*[2]) rather than the regular gaokao, only a quarter of the high school graduating cohort entered college in 2019. Students in another school, Raja, did not do any better. The Raja school is a minban school for Tibetan students who have either never attended school, or who have previously dropped out of public primary or secondary school, or for students who have exceeded the age limit of compulsory education. There are many orphans and poverty-stricken children in this school. All the students are Tibetan, and few of them have developed any real academic foundation.

Today, education success in China is closely linked with ideal jobs, social status, financial independence, and a better life (Kipnis 2011). Given this, the Chinese basic educational system, whether in metropolises or remote areas, still arguably adopts and emphasizes academic achievement. According to the fieldwork in these two schools, however, academic-oriented learning is not as effective among these Tibetan adolescents. It is obvious from our fieldwork that many Tibetan students are frustrated with their school's regular academic activities. It seems that only providing high-quality

educational resources to these Tibetan children did not directly solve long-standing issues of Tibetan education.

This study is an attempt to answer the question: why is it difficult for these Tibetan students to improve their academic performance in such well-resourced schools? Drawing on the fieldwork as well as in several Tibetan inhabitant regions in Qinghai, we found that family issues were repeatedly brought up by students and teachers. Based on our analysis, the "absent family" is a metaphor we used to understand how family life impacts students' academic learning. Specifically, we looked at how students' previous family experiences were felt, lived, and embodied in their academic pursuits.

Though the association between family education and children's educational outcome is well-documented (Brooks-Gunn and Duncan 1997; Hannum 2000; Lareau 2011), Tibetan family educational practices have rarely been researched, especially in regards to the Tibetan household views on their children's education. As a substantial domain for children's academic performance as well as individual development (Conger, Conger, and Martin 2010; Sarsour et al. 2011), family plays a critically important role in a range of developmental outcomes for children. By using a qualitative approach, this study aims to address the issues in family education in Tibetan families. We used students' self-report, teacher interviews, and parent interviews to examine family education issues in Qinghai province, one of the major inhabitants of Tibetans.

This paper is structured as follows. In the next section, we introduce our research sites, followed by a description of our methods and data. We used a qualitative approach to gather information from students, teachers, and parents/guardians, and categorized our findings under three subheadings. Our argument is that the family has both a structural and substantive impact on children's academic learning. The usual disclaimer applies to this project: it is a small-scale qualitative research project, which aims to identify typical cases. The findings should be corroborated with other types of evidence.

Research Sites

This study is based on data from a larger project investigating the disenchantment of Tibetan students in ethnic rural China. The empirical data presented in this study derives from twelve months of ethnographic fieldwork conducted between 2019 and 2020. The data was collected in two Tibetan-serving schools in Qinghai province of Northwest China. The students of the two schools mainly come from the Three-River Headwater (TRH henceforward) region, which is the main settlement of Tibetans in Qinghai.

The first site is a minority secondary boarding school—the TsuGur minority secondary school (*pseudonym*). It is set up especially for Tibetan students from the TRH region. TsuGur is 800 kilometers away from the TRH region and is a full-time boarding school. It is located in a multi-ethnic city in Qinghai with a population of more than one million. It is a combined junior and senior high school (*wanzhong*) that provides both lower secondary education (grades 7 to 9) and upper secondary education (grades 10 to 12). At present, there are more than 3,600 students in this school, almost 96% of the students are Tibetan, and more than 90% of the students are from low-income

nomadic families. Many of the parents have low educational attainment levels, and their families make a living by grazing or working outside as migrant workers. Educational officials claim that the Tibetan children from the TRH region, a harsh natural environment with poor teaching conditions, will get high-quality educational resources and achieve a bright future when placed in urban and modern settings.

The second site of this research is a Tibetan vocational secondary school—the Raja Tibetan vocational school (*pseudonym*). It was founded by a Tibetan Buddhist monk in a county in the TRH region. In 1994, many Tibetan children in the region dropped out of school as their families could not afford school fees. The enrollment rate of school-age children was only 19% at that time. Monk Jigme was pained to see the situation of unschooled children, and was thus inspired to set up a school in this county. The Raja school was a *minban* school for school-age Tibetan children who had never attended school, or for those who dropped out from public primary or secondary school, or for students who had exceeded the age limit of compulsory education. As such, few of these students had developed any real academic foundation. The Raja school is comprised of a basic culture department and a vocational high school department, with a total instructional duration of six years. The basic culture department has preparatory classes, junior classes, and intermediate classes. Students in the basic culture department study the national textbooks for compulsory education. The vocational high school department mainly focuses on vocational skills training and improving the employment level of the students. At present, there are more than 1,500 students in this school, all of whom are Tibetan, most of whom are from low-income nomadic families.

Students of both schools are not allowed to leave the school grounds unless their parents come to pick them up during weekends or holidays. However, few parents were able to visit the school because of long and difficult journeys. Every winter and summer vacation, students are transported to and from the school via an arranged bus. When a new semester begins, the school sends a bus to pick up students as well.

Methods and Data

Field visits began in September 2019 and ended in September 2020. After careful selection, we chose the aforementioned two schools as our field sites for a larger project. We wanted to compare two different contemporary, Tibetan-serving schools. Both schools are large in size with a substantial Tibetan student body. Both schools reflect the many issues embodied by contemporary Chinese schooling in that most students are from pastoral herdsman families, many students have a low level of parental involvement in a boarding environment, and there is low academic performance in general.

We combined participant observation with semi-structured interviews in our daily field activities. Our observational data included students' classroom and out-of-classroom learning, teacher-student daily interaction, school activities, and family visits. We conducted in-depth interviews with students, teachers, parents/guardians, school administrators, and school staff. Informal conversations were also conducted with the participants and some villagers. In TsuGur, thirty lower-secondary students, twenty-six upper-secondary students, twenty-two teachers, two schoolmasters, seventeen parents/guardians, and twelve school staff were interviewed in total. In the Raja school,

twenty-two lower-secondary students, twenty-eight upper-secondary students, and sixteen teachers were interviewed in total.

Interviews with parents/guardians were conducted mainly through daily talks. Part of the household interviews was conducted by the first author in the TRH region. Another part of the parental interviews was conducted in both schools when parents were waiting outside the buildings to pick up their children. In total, thirty-nine parents/guardians were interviewed. Among the parents/guardians who agreed to be interviewed, 25 were males, and 14 were females. Questions were asked about their personal background, their family background, their idea of child education, and their hopes for their children's future. The interviews were conducted in Tibetan, taking about 40 minutes with the assistance of our Tibetan assistant. We recorded interviews with Tibetan parents who cannot speak Chinese and then translated the recording into Chinese. All text-based materials were organized by the qualitative data analysis software NVivo 12 for coding, thereby identifying themes and the relationship between categories (Deterding and Waters 2021).

The first author has served as a volunteer teacher in two schools under the arrangement of the principals. In the two schools, as outside researchers, we were given much autonomy to participate in any school activities. These positions allowed us to gain access to diverse educational and extracurricular activities in the two schools. We were able to fully participate in school events, such as having meals with teachers and students, school sports and arts activities, and assisting school administrators in dealing with student affairs. All of these interactions afforded us with a more nuanced image of the school lives of students. Also, we spent much time outside the school, traveling into several Tibetan autonomous prefectures of the TRH region and learning about their culture, customs, habits, and living conditions.

One year of ethnography work offered us devoted immersion in the city and school to better understand the social and cultural environment, where the students have to navigate between Han and Tibetan culture, between the market economy and nomadic life, and between modern family structure and traditional family structure. Although we could communicate with students in Mandarin Chinese, and actually some of the students speak Mandarin quite well, it took the first author some effort to learn the Tibetan language and common daily expressions. Through this, we established rapport and trust with Tibetan students and parents, as well as improved conversational authenticity. All interviews were conducted in Mandarin Chinese except for the interviews with parents. In the cases where Tibetan students could not understand our expressions or they could not find a proper equivalent word in Chinese to express their feelings during our conversation, we asked them to write down the Tibetan expressions and then sought help from a Tibetan language teacher to translate the text.

Analysis

This current paper is grounded in a larger project in which the authors explore contemporary Tibetan school culture. Our interest in understanding students' academic learning via the lens of the family started after learning about the school reports and talking

with teachers. We were struck by the number of times students and teachers explained to us how their family lives influenced their learning.

Our coding of the data leads us to three distinctive categories. Through our fieldwork, we were able to garner deeper insight into the Tibetan students' lackluster academic performance, and the realities of their situations are far more complex than the following general following findings: (1) parental SES disadvantages hinder children's educational achievement, and Tibetan families lack the social and cultural capital that is conducive to Tibetan children's survival in mainstream China society; (2) complex family structures have a negative impact on Tibetan children's educational outcomes; (3) traditional Tibetan value systems from the pastoral community are misaligned with schools' learning culture. We analyze each finding in detail below.

Family Socioeconomic Status

A great deal of research has examined the effect of family socioeconomic status (SES) on children's educational achievement and cognitive development (Brooks-Gunn and Duncan 1997; Hannum 2000; Noble et al. 2015). Normally, family SES is characterized by parental educational attainment, occupation, and family resources. Most research found that children from lower SES families have poorer school achievement, particularly in regards to math and language skills (Lockheed, Fuller, and Nyirongo 1989; Raviv, Kessenich, and Morrison 2004). The improvements in family income could lead to beneficial outcomes for both children and parents (Malecki and Demaray 2006; Morris, Duncan, and Clark-Kauffman 2005; Stash and Hannum 2001). There is a growing body of evidence that suggests that household SES contributes to a broad set of developmental outcomes, including school achievement (Toutkoushian and Curtis 2005), physical health (Chen, Matthews, and Boyce 2002), cognitive functions (Kaplan et al. 2001), and mental health (Essex et al. 2006).

During the process of this current study, we discovered that most low-achieving students in the two schools were from low-income nomadic families. As Hannum (2002) claimed, poverty and geography contribute to the educational gap between the Han majority and ethnic minorities in China. In 2019, according to the Qinghai Statistics Bureau, the per capita disposable income of rural residents in Qinghai's six Tibetan Autonomous Prefectures is RMB 11,556 (approximately USD $1,785), just 37.6% of the national average. In addition to poverty, many of the Tibetan parents are illiterate herdsmen. They have low educational attainment levels, and their families make a living by grazing or working outside as migrant workers. Damba Gyatso, the Tibetan vice-principal of the TsuGur school, expressed his concerns:

> I was born and grew up in the region, and I am well aware of the problems we Tibetan face. Almost all the parents of our school are illiterate herdsmen. Many students are from low-income families. Due to lack of money and the long family-school distance, Tibetan parents usually show less concern about their children's learning. This led to a separation of family-school relations. Before coming to the school, many students spent their days helping families graze or do chores at home. Few of them developed any learning foundation.

Even with the recent policy support to expand school access, Tibetan students who entered schools found themselves lacking the social capital and cultural capital to support their academic learning. Using Bourdieu's conceptual framework, sociologist Lareau

(2011) proposed that middle-class parents were often deeply involved in all aspects of children's growth. She called it "concerted cultivation," through which parents create a variety of learning experiences for children. Thus, these children are more likely to get training in a range of rules of social games. Concerted training has become a crucial weapon that plays an important role in children's social interaction. Subsequently, Calarco (2018) argued that middle-class parents always depend on their social capital, like the interaction between friends, peers, relatives, and communities, to help their children to be more successful. Therefore, social and cultural capital, as a connecting network, stimulate and strengthen the habit of "learning" among students. These social norms and cultural practices are widespread among urban students. They can easily accept the learning-oriented educational objectives. For urban households, city lives and professional jobs can both reproduce parental socioeconomic status (Postiglione 2009). The cultural capital gained through knowledge of the language, mainstream culture, social interactions, and professional skills helps students perform well in their future life.

The students we interviewed show more of a resemblance to Lareau's working-class children. Their parents adhered to the "accomplishment of natural growth" ethos when their lives are less structured around learning activities. Tibetan people have been living on the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau for generations. They are used to the relatively closed grazing life in the high-altitude herding areas or living between nomadic and urban economic life. Tibetan students seldom have any social training, language abilities, learning experiences, and social networks that they can benefit from, nor do their parents or guardians have any advantages of cultural or social capital, which is conducive to their children's survival in mainstream China society.

Thus, owing to the deficient support of social and cultural capital, many Tibetan students from nomadic families do not take an interest in academic learning or treat it seriously. Dolkar, a Tibetan math teacher with 30 years of teaching experience in TsuGur, explained her perceptions:

> Unlike parents in big cities who invested a lot in their children's education, most Tibetan parents are illiterate, and they do not pay much attention to their children's studies. Also, parents don't have any social connections, and they have little contact with Han people. Thus, in such an environment where all the people are Tibetan, and they all share the same ideas, students can not feel the social or peer pressure, which is not conducive to their learning in the school.

Differing from families with higher socioeconomic status, Tibetan herdsmen parents usually show less motivation and strength in school participation owing to the lack of knowledge, time, energy, and money. Many herdsmen parents cannot afford the home-school transportation expenses. Few parents were able to meet their children regularly due to the long journey from their homes. They also have to tend to their livestock every day, and they seldom travel long distances. Families generally received information about their children's school life from relatives and friends by those who had been to the relocated school. But more often, the herdsmen families had little information about schools.

Family Structure

A large number of studies have investigated the effects of family structure and size on educational outcomes. For instance, there is abundant evidence to show that single

parenthood has a negative impact on children's educational outcomes (Amato 2001; Krein and Beller 1988; Martin 2012). There is a greater probability of school dropout and lower achievement for children from broken households (Wu, Schimmele, and Hou 2015). These effects have been mainly attributed to parental socioeconomic stress and parental involvement (Magnuson and Berger 2009; Sarsour et al. 2011; Seltzer 1994). Family size also has far-reaching negative consequences for children's educational prospects, especially in developing countries (Blake 1989; Black, Devereux, and Salvanes 2005; Pong 1997). For example, Parish and Willis (1993) noted that later-born children receive more education than early-born siblings, and they are more likely to benefit from the economic resources provided by older siblings. The predominant explanation for the relationship between sibship size and educational outcomes is the "Resource Dilution Model," which posits that physical and parental resources are diluted with additional children in the household (Buchmann and Hannum 2001).

Children's growing conditions are often cited to be one of the indispensable contributing factors to their future success. As Postiglione (2009) reported, Tibetan rural and nomadic households generally have more children, less income, and poorer access to health care. Through the fieldwork, however, what shocked us was that a large number of the students of two schools come from families with a variety of structures. Many children are orphans or come from single-parent families. This is mostly caused by their harsh living environment, poor medical conditions, and some traditional Tibetan customs.

Specifically, the extreme climate on the plateau often results in people's shorter lifespan and fatal accidents. As Huang, Rosenberg, and Wang (2018) reported, the mortality rate in the Tibetan plateau is much higher than in eastern and southern China, areas with moderate climates. In China's remote Tibetan regions, many students have lost their parents at a very young age due to harsh climate as well as poor health care. The severe environment also leads to more accidents in the region. In our study, apart from natural causes, some of the students' family members died in traffic accidents. Mountain roads in the region are often covered by heavy snow all year round, resulting in frequent highland traffic accidents. Most of the accidents are due to bad weather, fatigued driving, and an extended trip to the hospital, delaying emergency healthcare.

Moreover, the sanitary conditions in Tibetan areas remain poor, especially for those nomadic families. High Altitude Sickness (HAS) such as heart disease, hypertension, hepatic hydatid, and tuberculosis is very common among Tibetan parents (Tiaoying et al. 2005). In our study, many of the Tibetan parents died of hepatic hydatid and tuberculosis in their middle age, according to the interviews. These two common diseases in Tibetan regions are mainly due to the herdsmen ingesting raw food, and not paying attention to personal hygiene, in addition to poor living environments and poor medical conditions in the Tibetan region.

Another factor that contributed to the unique family structure of the Tibetan students was the marital practices. Despite the fact that the Tibetan traditional practice of fraternal polyandry has gradually disappeared, there were some students from polygamous families. The family structure of some Tibetan teenagers in our study remains complicated. Some Tibetan students lived with large size extended families with lots of uncles,

aunties, cousins, brothers, and sisters. Ugen, a 14-year-old boy from the TsuGur school, told us about his family:

> I am the youngest child in my family. I have three brothers and four sisters. Most of them didn't go to school and were married. There are two men in our family. I call them both dad. I had been living in my "big" dad's house before I came to this school. My "little" dad worked outside to earn money, and my big dad stayed at home to do some farm work.

Similarly, Sangmo Kyi, the dean of student affairs of Raja school, told us about the students' family background at the Raja school:

> There are many incomplete families in Tibetan regions, especially in pure pastoral areas. Polyandry has been a custom in pastoral areas since ancient times. Although this situation (polyandry) is rare today, some remote pastoral regions in Yushu (one of the Tibetan Autonomous Prefectures in Qinghai) still have this custom. Nowadays, there are many divorces in Tibetan areas. A divorce is a big event for those of us who have been educated. But it seems that the herdsmen have different ideas. In their opinion, whoever takes care of the children is fine for both husband and wife, and they rarely fight for custody of the kids after the divorce. There are also many Tibetan people who suffer from high-altitude diseases and live short lives. When I went to do the home visit, many were single-parent families, especially single-mother families.

Lack of parental involvement is the key disadvantage of children from complex household structures and large family sizes. Deficits of parental participation such as talking about school-related issues, monitoring children's behavior, and helping with children's homework have shown to contribute to Tibetan children's poorer academic performance (Wu, Schimmele, and Hou 2015).

Furthermore, the complex family structure also makes Tibetan children sentimental, which pushes children to think more of their family interests rather than themselves. Each time the students mentioned their parents or relatives, many of them shed tears in front of us. Kunga Tashi, a 14-year-old Tibetan boy from the TsuGur school, stammered out his concern with tearful eyes:

> My mother passed away a long time ago, and my father was confined to bed with tuberculosis. My elder brother didn't go to school since he was ten years old, and he is the only laborer in my family. If I can't go to college in the future, I just wish to get my high school diploma and go back to my hometown to take care of my father and help my brother with the daily chores.

Dexi, a graduate of the Raja school, decided to take care of his family in the future:

> My family is in financial difficulties. My parents often get sick. My father was injured when he went out to work and was disabled accidentally. My mother is also a patient, so I'm worried about them. I want to take care of my parents and siblings after graduation.

Sickly parents and family financial burdens are the main reported reasons why students wished to go home and take care of their families instead of focusing on their academic learning. Unlike the school's belief that teenagers need to stay focused on academic learning, Tibetan students see themselves taking up adult roles and household obligations, such as helping out with household chores, digging up cordyceps, and looking after younger siblings. For many Tibetans, schooling as a delay to family responsibilities brought fewer benefits to them under their specific social and cultural circumstances.

Values

According to Buchmann and Hannum (2001), parental values and preferences, family cultural beliefs, and household proposition of education have a great impact on children's academic and life development. Before living on school grounds, the family life of rural students was dominated by traditional Tibetan religious values. Many students in pastoral areas spent their days helping families graze or do chores at home. Tibetan students were given more adult roles and household obligations. Especially for children from illiterate nomadic families, strict obedience to parents/elders is regarded as one of the most important parts of traditional Tibetan education (Postiglione 2009; Postiglione, Jiao, and Gyatso 2005). At the epistemological level, the traditional Tibetan value systems from the pastoral community are in misalignment with the school's learning culture. Many Tibetan parents' perception of child-rearing is out of sync with the mainstream values of child-rearing in Han-centric urban regions.

Li et al. (2017) found that children from religious families are more likely to drop out of school than other children, especially those practicing Tibetan Buddhism. This probably depends far less on family income than on the perception of "the value of education." Whether ethnic schools or not, the academic record remains the most important way of evaluating students in China. Despite the fact that the evaluation system of China's middle schools is mainly oriented to academic performance, many schools in Tibetan pastoral communities still have different evaluation systems for students.

Before secular public education was promoted in Tibetan regions, it was monastery education, community education, family education, and other traditional education forms that take the responsibility of ethnic education as well as cultural transmission. Influenced by the culture of Tibetan Buddhism, having a noble character plays an important role in evaluating Tibetan people. Compared with having good morality, academic achievement is less important for many Tibetan teachers, parents, and students. As Muha, a 54-year-old Tibetan language teacher with 30-years of teaching experience in Tibetan pastoral schools described:

> Almost all schools in Tibetan pastoral regions attach more importance to students' moral character [than to academic learning]. In addition to the test score, good morality such as kindness, honesty, courage, and integrity is the implicit consensus of Tibetan communities and schools in evaluating students. If any one of our Tibetans is of bad moral character, he/she will be despised by all Tibetans, even the beggars.

Compared to TsuGur, the Raja school prioritizes personality and high moral standards as the most important educational values of the school. At the end of each semester, the Raja school always awards students of high moral character instead of the students with good academic performance. Also, the main reason why many parents send their children to the Raja school is that they firmly believe that modern secular schooling emphasizes academic learning rather than cultivating what they consider to be the good personal qualities of the Tibetan tradition. Hence, many Tibetan households prefer religion-centric local schools as they better reflect the aspirations of nomadic life.

Furthermore, as Kipnis (2011) described, the emphasis on the virtues of spirituality and moral standards are not unique but common characteristics in almost all agricultural or religious societies. These Tibetan students' learning mostly took place in a natural environment. In such a pedagogical pattern, the natural tendency of knowing

occupies a dominant position, in which literacy is not merely linguistic. In religious-centered communities, students' daily life revolved around religious activities, such as spinning the prayer wheels, participating in rituals, following their parents to pilgrimage, and worshiping holy mountains and lakes. To be educated in Tibetan Buddhist culture is about the development of noble character, about holding a holistic view of the world, about seeking inner enlightenment and a peaceful path inward, and about seeing the world as relations without strict segmentation between the human and nonhuman (Powers 2007). Therefore, the logic of indigenous epistemologies is often inconsistent with modern schools' understanding of learning.

Certainly, parents do know that academic learning is the best way out of poverty for their children. However, consistent with Bangsbo's (2008) findings, many Tibetan parents in this study expressed their helplessness about the narrow employment opportunities and the dim job prospects for Tibetan graduates. As Sonam Nima, a senior student's father from the TsuGur school stated:

> Now there are more and more college graduates. Our Tibetan children have no advantages in big cities and everything depends on their own efforts. Those who can go to college certainly have a bright future, but many of our (Tibetan) children can only go to work in cities or go home to help with the housework.

Indeed, lots of the parents were persuaded to support their children's studies because of the possibility of finding a good job and improving their living standards after graduation. However, as Wu (2012) remarked, the weakening correlation between schooling and employment has become a common national phenomenon. The employment trajectory of Tibetan students is determined not only by the vicissitude of the job market but mostly by their family SES, social and cultural capital, and living environment. The family education these Tibetan students received from childhood prepares them, mostly, only for entering sweatshops. For many children of herdsmen, they completed school life inexperienced. They continue to live a land-bound life rather than transition into state employment.

Moreover, Tibetan people's farming and herding life has been increasingly replaced by tourism in recent decades as the beautiful landscape of the TRH region is developed and promoted by the local government. Through our fieldwork, the invasion of tourism and commerce also has marginalized the importance of schooling in Tibetan regions. Many children were engaged in tourism to earn money in their hometown village, and their families did not think it was necessary to go to school.

The evaluation system in a certain field is one of the indicators that reflects its social capital. Before relocation, the Tibetan students seldom realize their poor learning foundations, and their parents/guardians are more open to schooling. Perhaps because the traditional Tibetan value system in their Tibetan communities did not put a particular emphasis on academic learning, it is not surprising that many students did not take academic learning seriously. The epistemic disparities between Tibetan people and mainstream society prevent them from academic pursuits.

Conclusions

Despite well-intended educational policies aiming at broadening access, the academic performance of Tibetan students remains visibly lagged. It seems that many Tibetan

adolescents did not respond actively to academic-oriented learning. Our analysis shows that schools cannot entirely make up for the disadvantages caused by the absent family. Using a production function analogy, not only does family contribute as an input resource, but it also endogenously shapes the very idea of schooling for the students we have met. Our analysis is anchored on three lines of thinking.

Firstly, academic learning is accumulative, which requires foundations. Modern academic learning demands plenty of effort from students. High-achieving students usually have a solid knowledge structure and practice regularly, typically as a result from parental involvement. In our case, there was no such input from the family side to cultivate such foundations as Tibetan adolescents' habitus—using the term of Pierre Bourdieu. Similarly, academic learning requires supervision and guidance. Tibetan students we interviewed rarely received that kind of attention from their parents. Many students' unique family structures did not grant them any help in learning. Lastly, the type of beliefs held by many Tibetan families run opposite of the school culture. The very idea of the necessity of academic learning was neglected, if not entirely resisted.

Our data shows that maintaining the learning trajectory thus proved to be very challenging at the secondary level. Students mostly drifted through the primary school years. Though socially promoted, deficits of learning gradually accumulated and inevitably led to poor basic knowledge, bad study habits, disinterest in learning, and no clear learning objectives. Therefore, the well-intended policies at the secondary level did not make up for lost opportunities. By pooling resources together and accommodating students in a centralized teaching facility, these students were given the opportunity to receive high-quality instruction. But our analysis showed that policies and an immersive learning environment could not push students to a level of academic learning that can be observed in many Chinese schools.

Could there be any more radical educational interventions? It is difficult for us to imagine the kinds of social policies that take children away from their parents. It is neither humane nor realistic to envision a kind of schooling regime where children are taken away from their families at early ages. Therefore, schools must somehow begin to solve those long-standing educational challenges in Tibetan pastoral areas, which formed a matrix of obstinate learning patterns or habits before the students attended school.

From a sociological perspective, habituation is not unchangeable, rather, it needs persistent pushing and molding to guide students toward academic learning. Alternatively, educators could try to find a middle-ground between schools and the family. In the two schools studied, the latter practices are what we found. In TsuGur, there was increasing emphasis on sports and art programs, which was exciting for the students. In Raja, vocational programs tailored to local employment were actively embraced. These practices were consciously adopted after the educators saw the impossibility of pushing students through the exclusively academic route.

To sum up, the findings of this study suggest that low family SES, complex family structure, and Tibetan value systems together contribute to Tibetan children's developmental outcomes. These "absent family" factors made it difficult for Tibetan children to thrive in an academic-oriented school environment. We hope this study will contribute to a deeper understanding of the problems existing in the family education of Tibetan

adolescents, as well as help us understand the dilemma of traditional Tibetan family education under the modernization discourse. Meanwhile, this is a small-scale ethnographic research project aimed at anchoring typical cases of Tibetan family education. The findings should be corroborated with other types of evidence.

Notes

1. ECP (Education Consolidation Policy 撤点并校) is a policy designed for rural schools (ethnic or non-ethnic) and has been implemented in China since 2001. The rationale behind ECP is efficiency and quality (Mei et al. 2015). Many rural regions in China are sparsely populated, therefore, village schools typically only have a handful of students. The ECP project aimed to consolidate village schools within a certain administrative radius into one school. That school's facilities are newly built and are typically better resourced. TBP (Two Basics Project 两基) is the abbreviation of universalizing nine-year compulsory education, basically eliminating illiteracy among young and middle-aged adults. Starting in 2004, TBP was primarily established to promote the development of education in the western region of China, thus improving the quality of life, and narrowing the educational gap between the east and the west of China. PDECE (Prevent Dropout and Ensure Compulsory Education 控辍保学) is a policy issued by the State Council of China in 2017. The purpose of PDECE is to prevent and control the number of student dropouts in the stage of compulsory education, to ensure that the consolidation rate of nine-year compulsory education will reach 95% by 2020, and ensure that school-age children receive compulsory education according to the law. TEOS (Two Exemptions and One Subsidy 两免一补) is one of China's educational assistance policies to promote the balanced development of compulsory education, which was implemented in 2001. It refers to a subsidy policy in which the state provides free textbooks, exempts miscellaneous fees, and subsidizes certain living expenses to boarding students from poor families at the stage of compulsory education (i.e., primary and junior high schools) in rural areas.
2. *minkaomin* (民考民) refers to a type of college admission exam for minority students based on their minority language. Minority students who enrolled in minkaomin will use their mother language to answer the exam. Differing from the National Higher Education Entrance Examination (*gaokao*), *minkaomin* has a separate enrollment plan and the admission score is much lower than *gaokao*. Minority students who take the examination of minkaomin can primarily apply only for the colleges or majors that have instruction in their own languages.

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